PADHAKU
Democratic Politics · Class 10 Social Science



CHAPTER 1

Power-sharing

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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🤔 Think · Belgium and Sri Lanka

? **I have a simple equation in mind. Sharing power = dividing power = weakening the country. Why do we start by talking of this?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

This equation is a common belief, but it is **wrong**. The chapter starts with it so that we can test it with real examples.

- Belgium **shared power** among communities and stayed united and peaceful.
- Sri Lanka **refused to share power**; this led to distrust and a long civil war that weakened the country.

So sharing power usually **strengthens** the unity of a country instead of weakening it.

Map **Look at the maps of Belgium and Sri Lanka. In which region, do you find concentration of different communities?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Belgium:

- Dutch-speaking (Flemish) people: in the **northern** region (Flanders).
- French-speaking (Walloon) people: in the **southern** region (Wallonia).
- German-speaking people: a small area in the **east**.

- Brussels-Capital Region: mixed – 80% French-speaking, 20% Dutch-speaking.

Sri Lanka:

- Sri Lankan Tamils: in the **north and east** of the country.
- Sinhala-speakers: in most of the rest of the island (south, west and centre).
- Indian Tamils: mainly in the central hill (plantation) areas (check the map in your book).

🤔 Think · Majoritarianism in Sri Lanka

? What's wrong if the majority community rules? If Sinhalas don't rule in Sri Lanka, where else will they rule?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Majority rule is fine for winning elections, but **majoritarianism** is harmful.

- In Sri Lanka the majority ignored the language, jobs and religion of the Tamil minority (Sinhala-only Act 1956, job preferences).
- The Tamils felt alienated; distrust turned into a civil war that killed thousands and set back the whole country.
- Democracy means the majority rules **while respecting the rights and wishes of minorities**.

So the Sinhalas can rule, but they should share power with the Tamils so that both feel the country is theirs.

🧪 Activity · Newspaper clippings on conflicts

Activity

Read any newspaper for one week and make clippings of news related to ongoing conflicts or wars. In a group of five:

- **Classify these conflicts by their location (your state, India, outside India).**
- **Find out the cause of each of these conflicts. How many of these are related to power sharing disputes?**
- **Which of these conflicts could be resolved by working out power sharing arrangements?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Model plan:

- Each student collects clippings for 7 days and pastes them with the date and newspaper name.
- Make a table with columns: |Conflict|Location|Cause|Power-sharing issue?|Can power sharing help?
- Group them under: our state / India / outside India.

- Causes can be: land, water sharing, language, religion, ethnic identity, border, demand for autonomy.
- Mark conflicts about language, region or community rights as power-sharing disputes. Many of these (e.g. demands for autonomy or minority rights) can be solved by sharing power – giving regions more powers, fair representation, or a share in government.
- Present the findings to the class on a chart.

? **So you are saying that sharing of power makes us more powerful. Sounds odd! Let me think.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

It is not odd. When every group gets a fair share in power, no group feels left out.

- Belgium shared power and stayed united and peaceful.
- Sri Lanka refused and suffered a civil war.

So power sharing reduces conflict and makes the country stronger and more stable.

🤔 Think · Why power sharing is desirable

? **Annette studies in a Dutch medium school in the northern region of Belgium. Many French-speaking students in her school want the medium of instruction to be French.**

Selvi studies in a school in the northern region of Sri Lanka. All the students in her school are Tamil-speaking and they want the medium of instruction to be Tamil.

If the parents of Annette and Selvi were to approach respective governments to realise the desire of the child who is more likely to succeed? And why?

✔ ANSWER

Annette's parents are more likely to succeed.

- Belgium has a power-sharing arrangement: the **community government** of each language group (Dutch, French, German) has power over cultural, educational and language issues, no matter where people live.
- So the French-speaking community government can look after French-medium education.
- Sri Lanka followed majoritarian policies (Sinhala as the only official language, Sinhala preference) and denied autonomy to Tamil areas, so Selvi's demand is less likely to be accepted.

⭐ Khalil's dilemma

? **If you had the power to rewrite the rules in Lebanon, what would you do? Would you adopt the 'regular' rules followed**

everywhere, as Khalil suggests? Or stick to the old rules? Or do something else? Can you help poor Vikram in answering Vetal?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Model answer: I would **keep power sharing, but make it more flexible**.

- The old rules brought peace after a bitter civil war; removing them suddenly may bring back fear and violence.
- But fixing posts by religion forever is unfair to people like Khalil who do not wish to be known by a religion, and the population has changed (Muslims are now a clear majority).
- So I would: keep guaranteed shares for all communities in the cabinet and parliament; let the top posts rotate among communities; and slowly allow open contest for some posts as trust grows.

This would keep peace and also move towards equal chances for every citizen.

🤔 Think · Forms of power-sharing

Cartoon

(Cartoon 'Reigning the Reins': In 2005 new laws in Russia gave more powers to its president; the US president visited Russia.) What, according to this cartoon, is the relationship between democracy and concentration of power? Can you

think of some other examples to illustrate the point being made here?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- The cartoon shows that **concentration of power in one person is against democracy**. Democracy cannot work when one leader holds all the reins.
- When power is concentrated, other organs of government and the people lose their checks on the ruler.
- Other examples: military rule in Pakistan under General Musharraf; the Emergency in India (1975–77), when the rights of citizens were suspended; dictatorships where one leader rules for life (check the picture in your book).

? **In my school, the class monitor changes every month. Is that what you call a power sharing arrangement?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

In a simple way, yes. Changing the monitor every month gives many students a turn to hold responsibility, so power does not stay with one student.

But it is mainly **rotation** of power. Real power sharing in a democracy means power is divided at the same time – among organs of government, levels of government, social groups and political parties.

? **Here are some examples of power sharing. Which of the four types of power sharing do these represent? Who is sharing power with whom?**

✔ ANSWER

Example	Type of power sharing	Who shares with whom
Bombay High Court orders Maharashtra Government to improve children's homes	Among different organs of government (horizontal; checks and balances)	Judiciary and executive
Ontario government's land claim settlement with aboriginal community	Among different social groups	State government and the aboriginal community
Two Russian parties unite into a right-wing coalition	Among political parties	Union of Right Forces and Liberal Yabloko Movement

Nigerian state finance ministers question the federal government on revenue	Among governments at different levels (vertical / federal)	State Governments and the federal government

📝 Exercises

1 **What are the different forms of power sharing in modern democracies? Give an example of each of these.**

✔ ANSWER

In modern democracies power is shared in four main ways:

1. **Among different organs of government** (horizontal distribution) – legislature, executive and judiciary. Each checks the others (checks and balances). *Example:* in India, judges can check laws made by Parliament and actions of the executive.

2. **Among governments at different levels** (vertical distribution / federal division) – central, state and local governments. *Example:* India has the Union Government, State Governments, and panchayats/municipalities.

3. **Among different social groups** – religious and linguistic groups, weaker sections and women. *Example:* 'community government' in Belgium; reserved constituencies in India.

4. **Among political parties, pressure groups and movements** – competition among parties and coalition governments. *Example:* coalition governments in India; interest groups of traders, farmers and workers influencing decisions.

Thus power does not remain in one hand.

2 **State one prudential reason and one moral reason for power sharing with an example from the Indian context.**

✔ ANSWER

Prudential reason: Power sharing reduces the possibility of conflict between social groups and ensures political stability. *Example:* India gave states to different language groups (states formed on linguistic lines), which reduced conflict and kept the country united.

Moral reason: Power sharing is the very spirit of democracy; people have a right to be consulted on how they are governed. *Example:* panchayats and municipalities in India let local people take part in decisions that affect them.

3 **After reading this chapter, three students drew different conclusions. Which of these do you agree with and why? Give your reasons in about 50 words.**

Thomman – Power sharing is necessary only in societies which have religious, linguistic or ethnic divisions.

Mathayi – Power sharing is suitable only for big countries that have regional divisions.

Ouseph – Every society needs some form of power sharing even if it is small or does not have social divisions.

✔ ANSWER

I agree with **Ouseph**.

- Power sharing is not only for divided or big societies; Belgium is a small country but power sharing worked well there.
- Power sharing is the very spirit of democracy: people have a right to be consulted on how they are governed (moral reason).
- It also prevents any one person or organ from becoming all-powerful and keeps order stable (prudential reason).

So every society needs some form of power sharing.

4 **The Mayor of Merchtem, a town near Brussels in Belgium, has defended a ban on speaking French in the town's schools. He said that the ban would help all non-Dutch speakers integrate in this Flemish town. Do you think that this measure is in keeping with the spirit of Belgium's power sharing**

arrangements? Give your reasons in about 50 words.

✔ ANSWER

No, this measure is not in keeping with the spirit of Belgium's power sharing.

- Belgium's model is based on **respecting all language communities** and accommodating them, not forcing one language on others.
- The community governments give each language group power over its own education and culture.
- Banning French imposes the will of the Dutch-speaking group, which is like majoritarianism, and can increase tension between the communities.

5 **Read the following passage and pick out any one of the prudential reasons for power sharing offered in this.**

"We need to give more power to the panchayats to realise the dream of Mahatma Gandhi and the hopes of the makers of our Constitution. Panchayati Raj establishes true democracy. It restores power to the only place where power belongs in a democracy – in the hands of the people. Giving power to Panchayats is also a way to reduce corruption and increase administrative efficiency. When people participate in the planning and implementation of

developmental schemes, they would naturally exercise greater control over these schemes. This would eliminate the corrupt middlemen. Thus, Panchayati Raj will strengthen the foundations of our democracy."

✔ ANSWER

Prudential reason: **"Giving power to Panchayats is also a way to reduce corruption and increase administrative efficiency."**

It is prudential because it stresses a better outcome (less corruption, more efficiency, removal of corrupt middlemen), not just the value of sharing power itself.

6 **Identify those arguments which are in favour of power sharing and select the answer using the codes given below. Power sharing:**

A. reduces conflict among different communities

B. decreases the possibility of arbitrariness

C. delays decision making process

D. accommodates diversities

E. increases instability and divisiveness

F. promotes people's participation in government

G. undermines the unity of a country

(a) A B D F (b) A C E F (c) A B D G (d) B C D G

✔ ANSWER

(a) A, B, D, F

These four are benefits of power sharing; C, E and G are arguments against it.

7 **Consider the following statements about power sharing arrangements in Belgium and Sri Lanka.**

A. In Belgium, the Dutch-speaking majority people tried to impose their domination on the minority French-speaking community.

B. In Sri Lanka, the policies of the government sought to ensure the dominance of the Sinhala-speaking majority.

C. The Tamils in Sri Lanka demanded a federal arrangement of power sharing to protect their culture, language and equality of opportunity in education and jobs.

D. The transformation of Belgium from unitary government to a federal one prevented a possible division of the country on linguistic lines.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) A, B, C and D (b) A, B and D (c) C and D (d) B, C and D

✔ ANSWER

(d) B, C and D

Statement A is wrong: in Belgium the leaders chose accommodation; the Dutch majority did not impose its domination.

8 **Match List I (forms of power sharing) with List II (forms of government):**

1. Power shared among different organs of government – A. Community government

2. Power shared among governments at different levels – B. Separation of powers

3. Power shared by different social groups – C. Coalition government

4. Power shared by two or more political parties – D. Federal government

(a) D A B C (b) B C D A (c) B D A C (d) C D A B

✔ ANSWER

(c) 1-B, 2-D, 3-A, 4-C

Organs → separation of powers; levels → federal government; social groups → community government; parties → coalition government.

9 **Consider the following two statements on power sharing:**

A. Power sharing is good for democracy.

B. It helps to reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups.

Which of these statements are true and false?

(a) A is true but B is false (b) Both A and B are true (c) Both A and B are false (d) A is false but B is true

✔ ANSWER

(b) Both A and B are true

Power sharing is the spirit of democracy and it reduces conflict between social groups.

🎉 **Chapter 1 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**